

Reach, target, and safety schools

How to actually build a balanced college list instead of guessing.

The three categories, explained:

Reach

A school where your grades and scores sit below the typical range of admitted students, or a school that is highly selective for almost everyone regardless of profile. Getting in is genuinely possible, just not the likely outcome.

Target

A school where your grades and test scores land solidly within the range of recently admitted students. Admission is realistic, though never guaranteed, since holistic review still applies here too.

Safety

A school where your profile is clearly above what is typically needed for admission, and one you would genuinely be glad to attend if every other option fell through.

The one line version

Reach means a real but unlikely chance. Target means a realistic chance. Safety means a strong chance, at a school you would actually be happy to say yes to.

Why this matters more than it sounds like it should

A list with no balance tends to fail in one of two directions. Applying only to reach schools can leave you with no offers at all come spring. Applying only to safe schools can leave you wondering, later, what else might have been possible. A balanced list protects both your options and your peace of mind.

Two separate things, a reach school and a fantasy school

This is the part almost nobody explains clearly. A real reach school still has a sensible, if unlikely, connection to your actual profile and interests. A fantasy school is one you add purely for the name, with no real connection to your grades, interests, or chances at all. A list full of fantasy schools is not actually a reach heavy list, it is a wasted set of application slots.

How to actually sort a school into a category

Most schools publish the middle 50 percent range of grades and test scores for their recently admitted students, either on their admissions page or in their Common Data Set. Compare your own numbers against that range for each school on your list.

Your position vs the middle 50 percent	Likely category
Below the published range	Reach
Within the published range	Target
Above the published range	Safety, if you would genuinely attend

Important nuance

A safety school only works if it is somewhere you would actually be glad to attend. If you cannot picture saying yes to it, it is not functioning as a real safety, it is just a wasted application slot dressed up as one.

How many of each, in one paragraph

There is no single correct number, but a common, sensible shape is around two or three reach schools, three or four target schools, and two safety schools. Adjust this based on how many applications you can realistically give real attention to, since a longer list with rushed essays usually performs worse than a shorter list done well.

Quick myths vs reality

Myth: The more reach schools I apply to, the better my overall odds.

Reality: Each reach school is an independently unlikely outcome, so adding more of them rarely moves your overall odds much. That time is usually better spent strengthening your target school essays instead.

Myth: A safety school means a lower quality school.

Reality: Safety only describes your likelihood of admission, not the quality of the school. Plenty of excellent schools function as a safety for a strong applicant.

Myth: Target schools do not need strong essays since I am already qualified.

Reality: Target schools often see the most competition among similarly qualified applicants, which makes your essays and supplements matter the most right there.

Building your list with this in mind

- Find the published middle 50 percent range for every school you are considering, usually on its admissions page or Common Data Set.
- Sort each school honestly into reach, target, or safety based on that range.
- Double check that every safety school on your list is one you would genuinely be glad to attend.
- Aim for a handful in each category rather than piling most of your list into reach.

Admitted student ranges shift year to year and can vary by major or program within the same school. Always check each school's current data on its own admissions page before finalizing your list.

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